

Fire and Ash

The art of the anagama kiln and natural wood-ash glazes

Wood-firing is the oldest way of making high-fired ceramics, and in Japan it remains among the most revered. In a wood kiln the potter does not simply apply a glaze and switch on a machine; the fire itself becomes a collaborator, depositing ash, drawing flame-paths across the clay, and finishing each piece in ways no one can fully predict.

The anagama kiln

The anagama is a single-chamber tunnel kiln built into or banked against a slope, a form that reached Japan more than a thousand years ago. Pottery centers such as Shigaraki built their reputation on it. Pots are loaded along the length of the chamber, and their final character depends heavily on where they sit in relation to the firebox and the path of the flame.

Days of fire

Unlike a gas or electric kiln, an anagama is stoked continuously by hand, often for three to five days and nights without pause. Red pine is the traditional fuel, prized for its resin and the quality of ash it produces. The crew works in shifts, reading the color of the fire to judge temperature and feeding the kiln to hold and slowly raise the heat toward stoneware temperatures around cone 10.

Natural ash glaze

The signature of wood-firing is the glaze that forms without being applied. As wood burns, fine ash is carried through the chamber and settles on the pots. At peak temperature that ash melts and fuses with the silica in the clay body, producing running, glassy surfaces and earthy textures. Surfaces facing the firebox catch the most ash; sheltered surfaces stay dry and toasted, so a single pot can carry the whole story of its firing.

Reduction and the read of the kiln

Toward the end of a firing the atmosphere is often pushed into reduction, starving the chamber of oxygen so the fire pulls it from the clay and glaze instead. Reduction shifts colors and deepens the warmth of the surface. Because conditions vary across the chamber, experienced potters place each piece deliberately, learning over years how the kiln runs hot in one corner and cool in another.

A philosophy of unpredictability

Wood-firing rewards patience and surrender in equal measure. The potter controls the clay, the forms, and the loading, then hands the finishing to fire and ash. Opening a cooled kiln is the moment of revelation, when the work emerges having done something the maker did not entirely intend. That partnership between human intention and material chance is the heart of the tradition.

A short field guide to wood-firing, written in the vocabulary of the studio: ash, reduction, cone 10, and the slow work that the fire finishes.